Creating accountability is our birthright," says Ahmedabad-based content creator Biswarup Goswami, 25. This was not samizdat. It was all out there, on public platforms, a disembodied body of anger, sublimated as humour, articulating what India's youth wished to say. Even the world media took notice: Reuters, BBC, Al Jazeera, NBC, Deutsche Welle, all ran reports. Was India's youth cohort, the world's largest at 371 million, not so quiescent after all? Youth rebellions had rumbled across the subcontinent, toppling regimes in Sri Lanka, Bangladesh, Nepal. Despite oblique exhortations, young India had seemed dutifully docile, prompting a wit to quip: "Other countries have Gen Z. India has Gen Zzzzz." Turns out India's youth are wide awake, perhaps even a little woke. "A youth upsurge may take place if this situation continues," says Tukaram Natkar, another competitive exam aspirant and farmer, in Selu, Maharashtra. Till now, though, the weapons have been memes, not Molotovs.

A BLEAK WORLD

Caught in a cesspool of diminishing dividends, India's famed demographic dividend had reason to meme away—they couldn't be blamed if life avenues appeared more dire and straitened than the Strait of Hormuz. Around the same time as the CJP's birth, NEET was being cancelled after a paper leak. Education often seemed a scam, or structured to favour the rich. With AI and the West Asian conflict, the job market is only getting bleaker. Politics and government seem to offer no solutions; elections seemed most efficient at reproducing the system endlessly. As for the judiciary, it had found judicious ways of keeping bright, young conscientious objectors in prison for years while ladling out bail liberally to worthies like Gurmeet Ram Rahim. On May 26, as the rape accused Dera Sacha Sauda chief was getting a 30-day parole, his 16th temporary release since 2020, the CJP, in the tenth day of its life, was already facing a difficult adulthood.

For a polity where public affairs are mostly a humourless cosmos, the CJP was a tricky commodity to negotiate. Humour can be subversive. But then, laughter cannot be legislated against, or quelled by teargas. The BJP, the obvious recipient of the upstart ripoff's nomenclatural dig, was not amused anyway. A video showed party functionaries in Karnataka catching cockroaches in a box and squashing them with slippers. The more serious crackdown came too, as the government invoked Section 69(A) of the IT Act to block the CJP's primary X account in India, citing "national security concerns". On his X account, Dipke gave the gloomy update: "Instagram page hacked, my personal Instagram hacked, Twitter account withheld...." He also received death threats, and police security was accorded to his parents back in Maharashtra. He approached the court against the ban, but the words were still insouciant. "Why is the government so scared of cockroaches? This dictatorial behaviour is opening the eyes of India's youth. Our only crime is we were demanding a better future for ourselves. But you can't get rid of us that easily. We are working on a new home right now. Cockroaches never die," he said.



AT 371 MILLION, INDIA HAS THE WORLD'S LARGEST YOUTH COHORT, WITH A LIVED REALITY GLOOMIER THAN ACKNOWLEDGED. ITS RESPONSE: SATIRE

But what kind of life can it look forward to? Joke parties abroad have often joined the mainstream, if only to mock it from the inside: the UK's Official Monster Raving Loony Party, the Polish Beer-Lovers' Party and their ilk contest elections, weaponising absurdity. Pune-based Rahul Kawthekar, still pursuing the state public services exam at 30, says the CJP, too, "must take the form of an alternative politics". The CJP professes no such ambition. Even its followers seem a trifle sceptical of it doing anything more than offering a platform for pent-up pique. Bidisha Chandra, a young Kolkata teacher, thinks of it as "a creative initiative to show dissent that was neither aggressive nor unlawful, without risking a jail term". Agnibha Sinha, 33, an assistant professor in Kolkata, signed up online, but saw little follow-up: "no invitation or update." Goswami feels the CJP "will not sustain the curve". Sen's credulity is touched even less. "You can't make a social media platform so popular in such a short time organically," he claims. "Youth disgruntlement is real, but this has a plan and a pattern," he says, ascribing his doubts to Dipke's past associations. But then, AAP itself languishes at 1.9 mn on Insta.

Political scientist Subhamoy Maitra has a bleak take that taps right into the ambient cynicism—he suspects the government "intelligently created an online outlet for youth anger". The CJP's cockroach, unlike the insect, may well prove to be transient, but like a flash of lightning, it lit up the landscape and made the darkness more visible. India's youth were meeting gloom not with anomic violence but with speech and self-deprecating wit. As a symptom, that holds more promise than peril, and India would do well to let them have the last laugh. ■

—with Arkamoy Datta Majumdar Jumana Shah and Dhaval S. Kulkarni